

FIELD NOTE • 2026 • TRUST & SAFETY • COMMUNITY OPS

The Giveaway Rule That Counted the Wrong Thing

Rewards attract whatever a rule can measure. A Discord giveaway rule counted joins rather than real members.

A reward attracts whatever the rule can measure. A rule that only sees a click gets clicks, and a rule that sees a stay is harder to fake.

The rule was simple. To enter, a member had to invite a few friends to the server, and those friends had to actually join. It sounds fair, and it measured something we could see: who invited whom, and who joined.

What it could not measure was whether those people were real. Some members met the condition and then their invited friends left right away. Others added their own alternate accounts to reach the number. We reviewed entries, but we were mostly checking whether the condition had been met. If the answer was yes, the rule had no complaint.

We did try to look closer. The first thing we checked was how old the account was. If it was new, the decision was easy: we banned it or skipped that winner. If it wasn't new but something still felt off, we looked at other details alongside the conditions. None of it gave certainty. We were community moderators, not Discord staff, so our tools were limited, and an older account could still be an alternate.

Our bar for banning was high. If we suspected someone of gaming the system, we had to be completely sure before acting, and we considered each case carefully. We did not apply one fixed rule to everyone. The length of the ban depended on the person's history and activity in the server, and it could be very long or permanent. Every ban came with a link to object, and responses varied. Some people never accepted the reason. Others apologized and admitted what they had done.

That high bar has a cost. Anything we were not sure about, we could not act on, so I can't tell you how many of the entries that passed were real. We reviewed everything and still could not be sure.

Some of what we missed, the community caught. Giveaways are competitive, and members who badly wanted the prize would challenge anyone they thought was cheating. They worked like a second verification layer, a human one, and they often noticed things we could not see.

This had a downside. Members sometimes accused people who had not cheated. That happened, and we always looked into those cases.

Beyond the bans, we changed the rule itself. We made the giveaway run longer, and an invited member had to stay in the server for a few days before the results and a few days after. For genuine new members, this was generally not a burden. We ran giveaways and small events often and enforced the conditions the same way each time. I believe that made most members careful about breaking them. I can't prove it. Not seeing attempts is not the same as nobody trying, and some may have gotten through unnoticed.

What I took from this: a reward attracts whatever the rule can measure. A rule that only sees a click gets clicks, and a rule that sees a stay is harder to fake. But I don't think the rule did the work alone. Consequences people believed in, and members who watched each other, probably mattered just as much.

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